

PM Interview Preparation

Simple Explanations with Examples for IT Project Manager Interview

What is this document?

This guide explains the new items in your CV. These are things that interviewers may ask you about.

Each topic has: (1) Simple explanation, (2) Why it matters for PM, (3) Example you can say in interview.

Read this before your interview. Practice saying the examples out loud.

Topic 1: Budget Management

What is Budget Management?

Budget management means planning how much money a project needs and tracking how much is spent. A Project Manager must know: How much will this project cost? Are we spending more than planned? Do we have enough money to finish the project? It is like planning your monthly salary -- you decide how much to spend on rent, food, transport, and savings. If you spend too

Every project has a budget (money limit). The PM must make sure the project finishes within this limit. If the project costs more than planned, the company loses money. The PM tracks costs every week or month and reports to managers. If there is a problem, the PM must find a solution quickly.

Key Words to Know:

- Budget = The total money available for a project
- Cost Estimation = Guessing how much money the project will need before it starts
- Cost Tracking = Checking every week: how much did we spend? Is it more or less than planned?
- Budget Variance = The difference between planned cost and actual cost (planned: 10,000, actual: 12,000 = +2,000 variance)
- Resource Cost = How much you pay for people, servers, tools, licenses

Example -- What to Say in Interview:

"In my projects, I tracked resources and delivery costs. For example, when we worked on the BNPL Credit Scoring project, I monitored developer hours, server costs, and license fees. I made sure we stayed within the planned budget by tracking costs weekly in Jira reports."

"Budget management is about planning and control. You plan how much you will spend, then you check every week to see if the actual spending matches the plan."

Topic 2: PMIS (Project Management Information System)

What is PMIS?

PMIS is a system (software/tool) that helps a PM manage all project information in one place. Think of it as your project command center. You can see: What tasks are in progress? Who is working on what? Are we on time? What are the risks? Are we over budget? The most popular PMIS tools are: Jira, MS Project, Asana, Monday.com, Trello. Jira is the most used tool in IT companies.

- Create tasks and assign them to team members
- Track sprint progress (burndown chart shows: are we finishing tasks on time?)
- Set milestones (important dates: project start, UAT start, go-live date)
- Generate reports (sprint report, velocity chart, release report)
- Manage backlog (list of all tasks, prioritized by importance)
- Track bugs and issues (who found it? who will fix it? is it fixed?)

Example -- What to Say in Interview:

"I used Jira as our Project Management Information System. I created sprint boards, tracked burndown charts to monitor progress, and generated sprint reports for stakeholders. Jira helped me see the status of every task in real time."

"A PMIS gives you visibility. You can see problems early and fix them before they become big issues."

Topic 3: Test Strategy

What is Test Strategy?

A test strategy is a plan that explains HOW you will test the project before it goes live. Think of it like a quality checklist. Before you deliver a product, you need to make sure it works correctly. The test strategy answers these questions: What will we test? (features, reports, payments) When will we test? (after development, before go-live) Who will test? (QA team, business users)

Test Strategy vs UAT -- What is the Difference?
Test Strategy = The big plan (QA team tests the technical side: Does the button work? Does the API return correct data? Does the report show accurate data?)
UAT (User Acceptance Testing) = Business users test the real scenarios (Can the operator create a loan? Does the payment go through? Does the dashboard work as expected?)

The PM does not do the tests, but participates in test strategy planning and coordinates UAT with business stakeholders.

Example -- What to Say in Interview:

"I participated in test strategy planning with the QA team. I helped define what to test, when to test, and who is responsible. For UAT, I coordinated with business stakeholders to create test scenarios and led bug triage meetings to prioritize fixes."

"Testing is not just QA responsibility. The PM ensures the whole quality process is organized and documented."

Topic 4: Change Management

What is Change Management in Projects?

Change management means handling changes that happen DURING a project. Imagine you are building a house. After you start, the owner says: 'I want 2 extra rooms.' This is a change request. As a PM, you must decide: Can we do this? How much more

Change Request Process (Simple Steps):
1. Someone requests a change (stakeholder says: "Please add this new feature")
2. PM analyzes the impact (How much more time do we need? Is it worth it? Every change must be documented, approved, and tracked.)

Without change management, projects go over budget and miss deadlines because people keep adding new requirements.

3. PM presents the analysis to the decision maker (manager or sponsor)
4. Decision: APPROVED or REJECTED
5. If approved: PM updates the plan, adds new tasks to Jira, informs the team
6. PM tracks the change until it is completed

Example -- What to Say in Interview:

"When stakeholders requested changes during the Credit Lifecycle project, I analyzed the impact on timeline and resources, presented the options to management, and after approval I updated the plan and added new tasks to Jira."

"Good change management means: every change is analyzed, documented, and approved before implementation. This prevents scope creep."

Topic 5: Resource Allocation

What is Resource Allocation?

Resource allocation means deciding WHO does WHAT and WHEN. Resources include: people (developers, QA, BA), time (how many hours/sprints), equipment (servers, licenses, tools). The PM must make sure resources are used efficiently. Example: If you have 3 developers and 2 projects, you must decide how many developers work on each project. If you give all 3 to one project

Example Scenario:
Team: 3 Developers, 1 QA, 1 BA

Project A (Credit Scoring): 2 Developers, 1 QA -- Priority: HIGH -- Deadline: March

Project B (Payment Gateway): 1 Developer, share QA -- Priority: MEDIUM -- Deadline: April

The PM decides based on: priority, deadline, and available capacity of each team member.

Topic 6: Power BI for Project Managers

How Does a PM Use Power BI?

Power BI is a tool for creating visual dashboards and reports. A PM uses Power BI to: Show project status to stakeholders (green/yellow/red dashboard), track KPIs (how many loans processed, how many errors, how many applications per day), present data-driven reports instead of text reports, and make better decisions based on data. The advantage of Power BI is: instead of sending a 10-page Excel report, you send one visual dashboard that managers can understand in 5 seconds.

Error Tracking: Shows number of errors per day (line chart) -- if the line goes up, there is a problem

- Team Performance: Shows burndown chart -- are tasks being completed on time?
- Budget Overview: Shows planned vs actual spending (donut chart) -- green = under budget, red = over budget

Example -- What to Say in Interview:

"I created Power BI dashboards for stakeholder reporting. For example, a sales dashboard that showed daily application volume and error rates. This helped managers see project status in one view instead of reading long text reports."

"Power BI makes data visible. When stakeholders can see the numbers in a chart, they make faster and better decisions."

Interview Tips -- How to Answer PM Questions

Use the STAR Method for Every Answer:

STAR means: S (Situation) -- What was the problem? T (Task) -- What did you need to do? A (Action) -- What did YOU do? R (Result) -- What was the outcome? Interviewers love STAR answers.

STAR Example for Budget Management:

S (Situation):

"We had a Credit Scoring project with a fixed budget and timeline."

T (Task):

"I needed to track costs and make sure we do not exceed the budget."

A (Action):

"I tracked developer hours and resource usage in Jira weekly reports."

R (Result):

"We finished the project on time and within budget."

Common Interview Questions to Prepare:

- How do you manage a project budget? (Use Topic 1 answer)
- What tools do you use for project management? (Jira/PMIS answer)
- How do you handle changes during a project? (Change Management answer)
- How do you ensure project quality? (Test Strategy + UAT answer)
- How do you allocate resources across multiple projects? (Resource Allocation answer)
- Tell me about a project where you managed risks. (Risk Management answer)
- How do you report project status to stakeholders? (Power BI + Status Reports answer)
- What is your approach to team coordination? (Stakeholder Management answer)
- Have you used Agile or Scrum? How? (Sprint planning, daily standups, retrospectives)

Final Tips:

- Always use real examples from your experience (Embafinans, Birbonus, Umico)
- If you do not know something, say: 'I have basic knowledge and I am learning more'
- Speak confidently -- your 15+ years engineering background is a BIG advantage
- Connect every answer to a RESULT (numbers, improvements, time saved)

